Who Knows What About Mom's Money?

A guide to the family conversation: one sitting to put what each of you knows on one list.

Your sister pays Mom's bills. Your brother did her taxes one year. You have the insurance folder. Each of you is holding a piece, and nobody has seen all the pieces side by side.

This guide is for one conversation with one job: put what everyone knows about Mom's finances on one list. It isn't for deciding what to do about any of it.

Who should be there

Mom, if she is able and wants to be. It's her money, and she may know things nobody else does. Then everyone who has handled a piece of it: the one who pays her bills, the one who helped with her taxes, the one whose name is on an account with hers. If Mom is married, her spouse belongs at the table too. Someone who can't come can send notes ahead.

Pick one person to take notes. It shouldn't be the person leading the conversation.

How to open

Start with Mom if she's there, and start with a question, not a conclusion. It may feel awkward. The Consumer Financial Protection Bureau says that even so, it is important to have an honest conversation about finances. [1]

- “Mom, the bills for your care have started coming and we want to handle them properly. Can you help us understand what you have and where things are?”
- “Each of us knows a piece of this. Nobody is checking up on anybody. We just want it all on one page.”
- Say what the conversation is for: one shared list. Say what it isn't for: deciding what happens to any account, the house or anything else.

Questions to ask

Ask Mom, if she's able

1. What comes in each month, and where does it come from?

2. Where do you bank, and where do you keep your statements, policies and important papers?

3. Is there an account, a policy or a property we might not know about?

Ask each other

1. What do you know for certain about Mom's income, accounts, insurance or property, and which papers do you have?

2. What do you pay or handle for her, and from which account?

3. Is your name on anything with Mom's: an account, a deed, a policy? Do you know who is named as a beneficiary on anything?

4. Which parts of this are we remembering, and which have we seen on paper?

5. What doesn't any of us know yet?

How to write down what was said

Keep what someone has seen on paper separate from what they remember. Where two people remember it differently, write both and don't settle it at the table. A statement or a call to the bank can do that later.

WHAT WAS SAID	WHO SAID IT	ON PAPER, OR FROM MEMORY	STILL TO CONFIRM
“There's a CD at the credit union. I think Karen's name is on it with mine.”	Mom	From memory	Karen hasn't seen any paperwork for it
Pays the electric and phone bills out of Mom's checking account.	Karen	On paper: the bank statements	

What not to decide yet

These take a professional who knows the rules where Mom lives, and your list is what makes that conversation a good one. Leave them open.

- What to do with any account, policy or property.
- Whether anything should be moved, spent, sold or put in someone else's name.
- How long Mom's money may last.
- Whether Mom may qualify for Medicaid.
- Who remembered it right.

What you can decide today

- Who will write up the list and send it to everyone.
- Who will look for each missing paper, or call the bank, the insurance company or the facility's business office.
- Who will take the open questions to your Medicaid planner or the appropriate licensed professional.
- When you'll talk again.

What this guide doesn't do

It doesn't resolve a disagreement, decide what happens to any account or property, or tell you what a professional will say. It gets your family to one list, with the differences and the unknowns left on it. Nothing here is legal, financial or tax advice.

Ready for the next step?

Your family has one list now, with the unknowns left on it. The planning interview takes that list further: it asks about your family's situation, question by question, and gives you a free planning report you can bring to any conversation about paying for Mom's care.

Get Your Free Planning Report ›

WHERE THIS COMES FROM

1. Consumer Financial Protection Bureau, Planning for diminished capacity and illness